Kataoka Kei on Dharmottara's Theory of Apoha (A Summary of His Published Papers)

Since around 2010, Kataoka Kei has reread the apoha theory of Dharmottara (c. 740–800) through the eyes of his Brahmin contemporaries and critics (Jayanta, Sucarita, Vācaspati), rather than only from inside the Buddhist tradition. This page summarizes, with figures and tables, the claims made in eight of his papers (2012h, 2013c, 2014a, 2014e, 2014f, 2016a, 2017e, 2018d).

> For Dharmottara, the object of conceptual cognition and of words is neither a form within cognition nor an external real. It is something fabricated (*āropita*): presented as existing although it does not exist. On this one point Dharmottara departs decisively from his master Dharmakīrti.

☐ external, real ☐ cognition, cognitive form ☐ the fabricated

1 Three models of apoha

2 *āropita* : fabricated, not superimposed

3 All four readings *adhyavasāya* rejected of

4 The real target is Dharmakīrti

5 Sameness is imposed from above

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↓ The papers at a glance

1. Three models of apoha 2010c · 2012h · 2014e · 2014f

> The Buddhist apoha theory developed in three stages: external, internal, and neither internal nor external. Dharmottara represents the third stage and takes a path different from Dharmakīrti's.

In his *Nyāyamañjarī*, the ninth-century Naiyāyika Jayanta presents the Buddhist theory of apoha in three forms. Kataoka uses this division as the framework for the history of the theory.

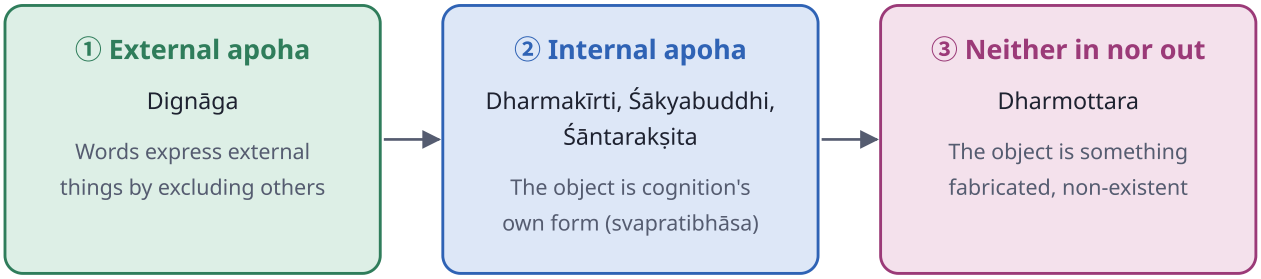


Fig. 1. Kataoka's arrangement, based on Jayanta's threefold division. Jayanta glosses the phrase "neither cognition nor external" (बुद्धिर्नो न बहिः) of AP's opening verse as "neither internal nor external" (नान्तर्न बहिः).

Against Frauwallner's assessment

Issue	Frauwallner (1937)	Kataoka
Relation to Dharmakīrti	Dharmottara changed nothing essential; he only "determined the nature of the object more sharply"	He replaced the object of conceptual cognition, from a cognitive form to **the fabricated**. This is a fundamental change
Understanding of *āropita*	A mental image superimposed onto an external object	Something fabricated though it does not exist
Contemporary views	Notes Jayanta's distinction in a footnote, but in the end ignores it	Jayanta's distinction is correct; Sucarita and Vācaspati make the same distinction (§6)
Background	Dharmakīrti is "not only the climax but also the end" of the development	There is original development after Dharmakīrti

Sources: Kataoka 2014e §1, §8; Kataoka 2014f, conclusions 1–2.

2. *āropita*: fabricated, not superimposed 2012h · 2014f · 2017e

> Dharmottara's key term *āropita* does not mean "A placed upon B" (superimposed). It means "presented as existing although it does not exist" (fabricated).

The words *samāropa* and *āropa* have two meanings. Which one we choose changes the whole picture of Dharmottara's theory.

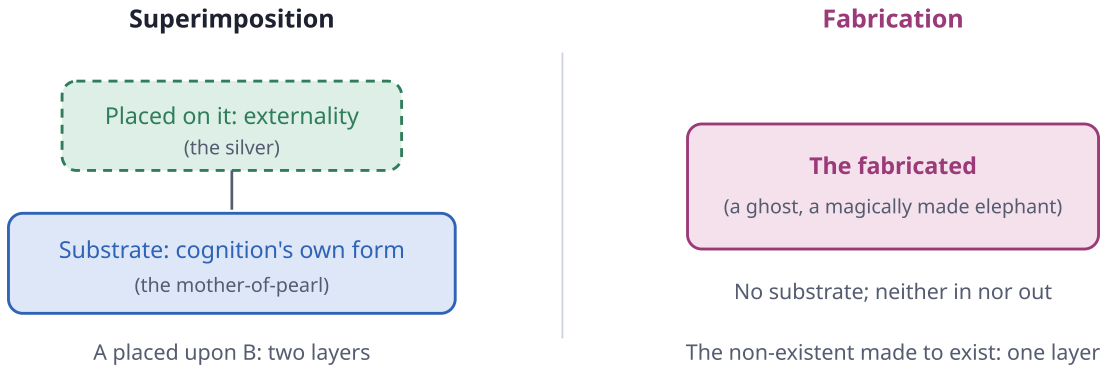


Fig. 2. Two kinds of *āropa*, after Kataoka 2017e §2. Ratnakīrti distinguishes the former as "grasping X in what is not X" (*atasmiṃs tadgrahaḥ*) and the latter as "appearance of the non-existent" (*asatkhyāti*).

Why "fabricated"

Evidence	Content
Dharmottara himself	His opening verse speaks of निस्तत्त्वमारोपितम् ("the unreal, the fabricated"). In AP §3.2 he explicitly rejects the superimposition view (see §3)
Jayanta	सो ऽयमारोपित आकारो न बहिः, आरोपितत्वादेव। नान्तः, अबोधरूपत्वात्। "It is not external precisely because it is fabricated." This reason does not work if *āropita* means "superimposed"
Sucarita	Sums up Dharmottara's view as कल्पितं निस्तत्त्वमलीकम् ("constructed, unreal, false")
Jñānaśrīmitra	आरोपितमित्यपि कल्पितमेवोच्यते। "What is called *āropita* is nothing but the *kalpita*," said in criticism of Dharmottara
Mahāyāna usage	*samāropa* can mean "positing the non-existent as existent," as in the *Laṅkāvatāra*'s "attributing a non-existent universal"

Sources: Kataoka 2012h (the two senses of *samāropa*); Kataoka 2014f, conclusion 3; Kataoka 2017e §2, §4 and conclusions 1–2.

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3. All four readings of *adhyavasāya* rejected 2013c · 2014f · 2017e

> Dharmottara lists four ways of understanding Dharmakīrti's "determination" (*adhyavasāya*) and rejects all of them, superimposition included. Akamatsu (1984) misread one of them as Dharmottara's own view.

In AP §3.2 an opponent offers four readings of what it means for conceptual cognition to "determine" its own form as external. Dharmottara accepts none of them.

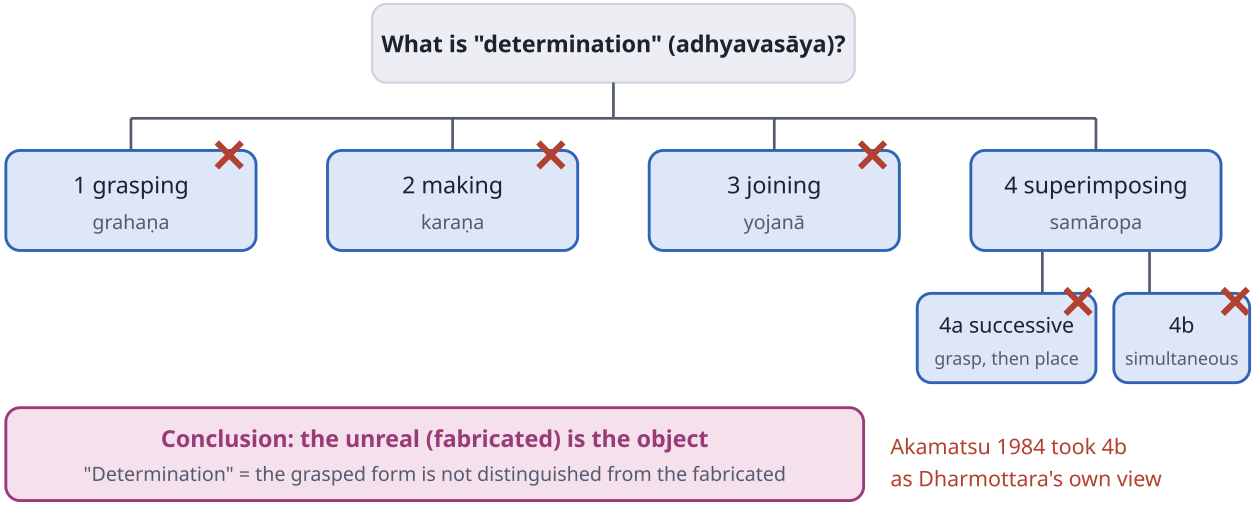


Fig. 3. Structure of AP §3.2 (after Kataoka 2017e, Table 7.1). Option 4b and the conclusion survive in Sanskrit, quoted by Jñānaśrīmitra: उल्लेखानुभवसमानकालं समारोपणमप्रतिभासरूपमेव, अवस्तु विकल्पविषयः।

Who held the superimposition view, and what became of it	Kataoka's assessment
Śākyabuddhi	Commented on Dharmakīrti's "determination" as "superimposition" (*adhyāropa*). The view Dharmottara criticizes can be traced back at least to him
Trilocana → Vācaspati → Ratnakīrti	Dharmottara's examination of the four readings was taken over by Trilocana, passed through Vācaspati, and was cited by Ratnakīrti, who divided it into twelve alternatives
Karṇakagomin	Followed Śākyabuddhi's wording but changed "by superimposition" to "by determination" (*adhyavasāyena*), apparently in view of Dharmottara's criticism

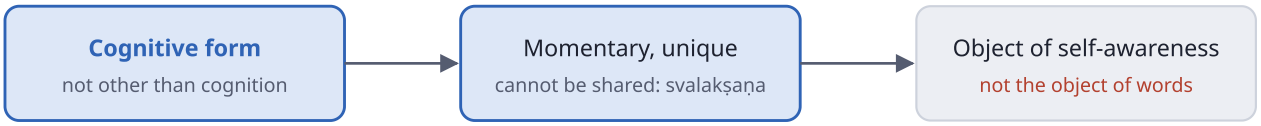
Sources: Kataoka 2013c (answering its title question, "What did Dharmottara deny in his apoha theory?"); Kataoka 2014f, conclusion 4; Kataoka 2017e, conclusion 3.

4. The real target is Dharmakīrti 2014e · 2014f

> What Dharmottara rejects is Dharmakīrti's own view that a cognitive form is the object of conceptual cognition. Since he cannot criticize his master openly, he criticizes him implicitly and reinterprets the passages that contradict him.

Dharmakīrti's passage	Plain reading	Dharmottara's reinterpretation (AP)
PVin II 46.7–8 acts by determining its own appearance as the object	Conceptual cognition determines its own form as external	"Determination" means that the grasped form (its own appearance) is **not distinguished** from **the fabricated**. What is determined is the fabricated (AP §3.3)
PV III 164ab, 165 words are bound to the images (pratibimba) of conceptual cognition	The object of words is the image in cognition	Two readings: (a) the form and the fabricated were spoken of as one because they are not distinguished; (b) "image" refers to the fabricated (AP §3.4). Kataoka regards this as a "forced" interpretation

Why a cognitive form cannot be the object



Just as pleasure, though self-aware, is not expressed by words (PV III 280 = PVin I 21)

Fig. 4. The basic idea of Dharmottara's critique of the cognitive-form view. Kataoka 2014f shows that Sucarita's explanation is modeled on this idea.

Sources: Kataoka 2014e §5–§6; Kataoka 2014f, conclusion 1.

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5. Sameness is imposed from above 2014e

> What makes distinct particulars "the same" is not that they produce the same effect, but that they share one fabricated object. Dharmottara revives Dignāga's top-down model without positing external reals.

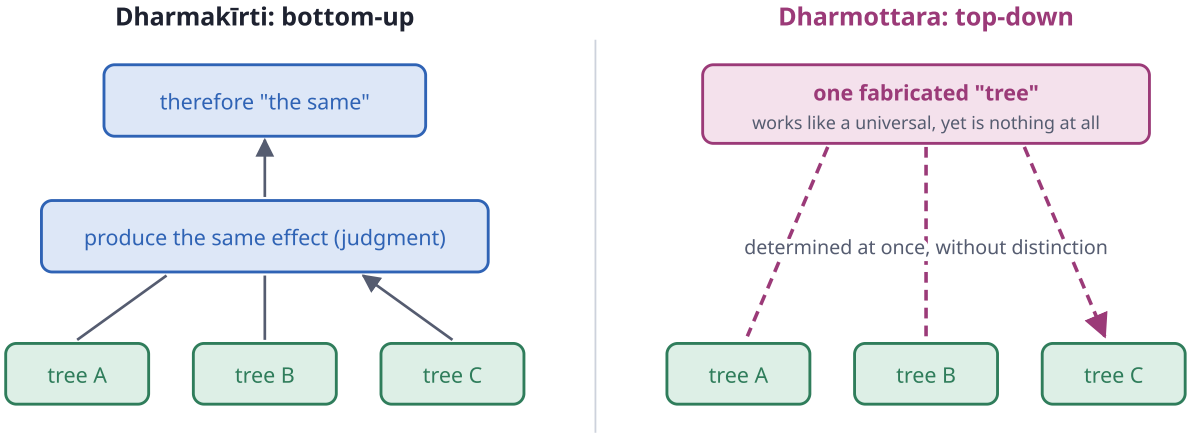


Fig. 5. How sameness arises. The decisive sentence is AP §9.8: "not because the effect is the same, but because the object is the same." Sucarita (*Kāśikā* 3.3.4) and Vācaspati (*Nyāyakaṇikā*) restate it in the same order.

	Dharmakīrti	Dharmottara
What makes particulars the same	Producing the same effect (judgment) (*ekārthasādhana*)	Having the same object (one **fabricated** thing)
Direct object of conceptual cognition	**A cognitive form** (different in each cognition)	**The fabricated** (one and shared)
Type of model	Bottom-up	Top-down (close to Dignāga)

In Dharmakīrti's model, different judgments count as "one" because they have the same form (image). But a form is not other than its cognition, so each is a distinct particular (*svalakṣaṇa*), and distinct particulars cannot be "one." Kataoka reads an implicit criticism of Dharmakīrti here.

Source: Kataoka 2014e §4, §7.

6. Brahmin authors saw two Buddhist theories

2014a · 2016a · 2018d

> Brahmin authors of the ninth and tenth centuries divided the Buddhist apoha theory into a cognitive-form theory and Dharmottara's fabrication theory, and criticized them separately. Treating Dharmottara's view as a distinct theory is not Kataoka's invention; it is how his contemporaries saw it.

Author	① Dharmakīrti's line (cognitive form)	② Dharmottara (fabrication)
Jayanta	A path containing *ātmakhyāti* (*ātmakhyātigarbhā saraṇiḥ*)	A path containing *asatkhyāti* (*asatkhyātigarbhā saraṇiḥ*)
Sucarita	"Some say it is its own form": *jñānākāravādin*	"Others say it is constructed, unreal, false"
Vācaspati	*jñānākāravādin*, *sākāravādin*	*nirākārajñānavādin*
Śālikanātha	—	Nothing at all, appearing after cognition, "like an echo after a sound"



Fig. 6. After Kataoka 2018d §6 and Kataoka 2016a. One source of Sucarita's understanding of Dharmottara is Śālikanātha's account.

Sources: Kataoka 2018d §4–§6 and conclusions 1–2; Kataoka 2014f, conclusion 5; Kataoka 2016a.

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7. Recovering the lost Sanskrit 2014a · 2016a · 2017e · 2018d

> AP survives only in Tibetan translation. Because Sucarita's *Kāśikā* and other works follow its arguments closely, parts of the Sanskrit can be reconstructed.

Kataoka has edited the previously unpublished apoha section of Sucarita's *Kāśikā* from four manuscripts (Kataoka 2014a, 2015a, 2019b). In it Sucarita closely follows the structure of Dharmottara's text.



Fig. 7. Sources for reconstructing AP's Sanskrit. Kataoka's reconstructions are given in Kataoka 2017e and 2018d.

Three characteristics of apoha (AP §6–§7)

	Sanskrit	Meaning
1	भावाभावसाधारण	Common to existence and non-existence ("the tree exists / does not exist")
2	बाह्यसदृश	Similar to the external (hence determined as external)
3	नियतरूप	Having a fixed form (not just anything)

Dharmottara himself sums up these three points, and Jayanta and Sucarita each restate them (in a slightly different order). Sucarita's *Kāśikā* is especially important for reconstructing this part of the Sanskrit.

Sources: Kataoka 2014a; Kataoka 2016a §5; Kataoka 2018d §10 and conclusion 3.

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8. Place in intellectual history 2012h · 2013c · 2014f · 2018d

> Dharmottara returned apoha to "mere non-existence." This is a return to Dignāga, and it parallels the *alīkākāravāda* line in Yogācāra theories of mental forms.

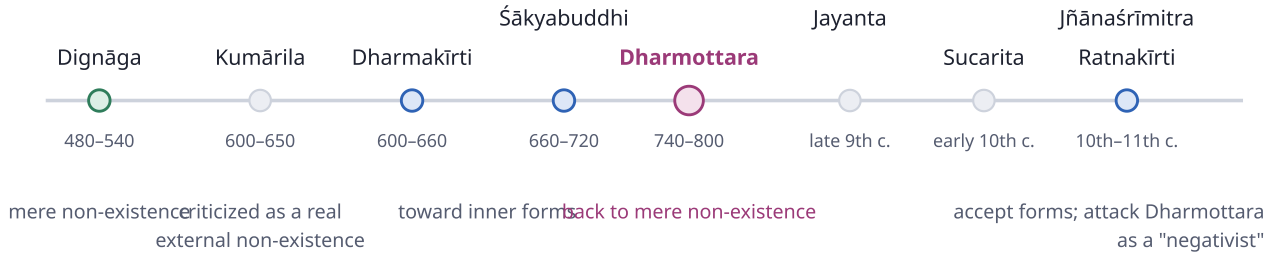


Fig. 8. Dates as given in Kataoka's papers (those for Dharmakīrti and Kumārila are conventional estimates).

Stage	How apoha (non-existence) is treated	Direction
Dignāga	A mere non-existence, not a substance (*adravya*); it does not stand between word and object	Not placed in an ontology
Kumārila	Recast, according to his own ontology, as a non-existence with reality, and its status questioned	Externalized
After Dharmakīrti	Explains how inner forms arise from particulars and how they relate to exclusion	Internalized
Dharmottara	Neither external nor internal; simply non-existent	Leaves ontology behind (return to Dignāga)

Theory of mental forms (Yogācāra)	Apoha theory	Representatives
satyākāravāda: forms truly exist	**Cognitive-form theory**: a form in cognition is the object of words	Śākyabuddhi, Śāntarakṣita, Jñānaśrīmitra, Ratnakīrti
alīkākāravāda: forms are imagined (*parikalpita*)	**Fabrication theory**: the fabricated is the object of words	Parallels the line Arcaṭa → Dharmottara → Ratnākaraśānti

Later developments

- Dharmottara's followers seem to have developed a revised version in which "the externality of the fabricated" (*āropitabāhyatva*, *alīkabāhyatva*) is the object of words. The term does not yet appear in AP; it appears in Prajñākaragupta, Vācaspati, Jñānaśrīmitra and Śrīdhara (Kataoka 2014a, 2018d).
- Jñānaśrīmitra and Ratnakīrti, who accept cognitive forms, criticized Dharmottara as a "negativist" (*pratiṣedhavādin*) (Kataoka 2017e, conclusion 4).
- Kataoka argues that the Ratnakīrti-based view of the history (Akamatsu's view) cannot explain how Jayanta and Sucarita saw things. He proposes that apoha theory after Dharmottara be viewed within the larger frame of an opposition between the cognitive-form theory and the fabrication theory (Kataoka 2014f, conclusions 5–6).

Sources: Kataoka 2012h; Kataoka 2013c §7; Kataoka 2014f, conclusions 5–6; Kataoka 2014a, 2018d.

The papers at a glance

Code	Title (short)	Main claims	Sections here
2012h	What is apoha?	Three views of the history of apoha; two senses of *samāropa*; Dharmottara's return to Dignāga	1, 2, 8
2013c	What did Dharmottara deny in his apoha theory?	He rejected the superimposition readings of *adhyavasāya*, including simultaneous superimposition; Akamatsu's misreading; transmission to Trilocana, Vācaspati, Ratnakīrti	3, 8
2014a	Sucaritamiśra's Critique of Apoha	Edition of the *Kāśikā* on v. 1; identification of AP fragments; the later notion of *alīkabāhyatva*	6, 7, 8
2014e	Dharmottara's Theory of Apoha	Critique of Frauwallner; implicit criticism and reinterpretation of Dharmakīrti; top-down sameness	1, 4, 5
2014f	Dharmottara's theory of concepts: superimposition and fabrication	Six conclusions (no role for cognitive forms, Jayanta's distinction, fabrication, rejection of the four readings, two-theory opposition, parallel with theories of mental forms)	1–4, 8
2016a	Sucaritamiśra's understanding of apoha	Japanese translation of the *Kāśikā*'s pūrvapakṣa on v. 1; relation to Śālikanātha; the three characteristics of apoha	6, 7
2017e	Dharmottara's Notion of *āropita*	*āropita* is fabricated, not superimposed; critique of Śākyabuddhi's superimposition view; criticism by Jñānaśrīmitra and Ratnakīrti	2, 3, 8

2018d	Sucaritamiśra on Apoha	Two Buddhist theories distinguished by Brahmin authors; Śālikanātha as Sucarita's source; reconstruction of the three characteristics	6, 7

About this page

This page summarizes eight papers by Kataoka Kei (2012h and 2013c were read from OCR text). The figures and tables are redrawn from Kataoka's own tables and arguments. Numbered "conclusions" refer to the numbered points in each paper's concluding section.

References

2012h Kataoka Kei. 「アポーハとは何か？」 [What is apoha?]. *Indo Ronrigaku Kenkyū* 5, 109–134.

2013c Kataoka Kei. 「Dharmottara は Apoha 論で何を否定したのか？」 [What did Dharmottara deny in his apoha theory?]. *Minami Ajia Kotengaku* 8, 51–73.

2014a Kei Kataoka. "Sucaritamiśra's Critique of Apoha: A Critical Edition of Kāśikā ad Ślokavārttika apoha v. 1." *Memoirs of the Institute for Advanced Studies on Asia* 165, 362(1)–289(74).

2014e Kei Kataoka. "Dharmottara's Theory of Apoha." *Journal of Indological Studies* 24 & 25 (2012–2013), 115–135.

2014f Kataoka Kei. 「ダルモッタラの概念論――付託と虚構――」 [Dharmottara's theory of concepts: superimposition and fabrication]. *Indo Ronrigaku Kenkyū* 7, 95–137.

2016a Kataoka Kei. 「スチャリタミシュラのアポーハ論理解――Kāśikā ad Ślokavārttika apoha v. 1 前主張の和訳――」 [Sucaritamiśra's understanding of apoha: a Japanese translation of the pūrvapakṣa of the Kāśikā on v. 1]. *Tetsugaku Nenpō* 75, 55–107.

2017e Kei Kataoka. "Dharmottara's Notion of āropita: Superimposed or Fabricated?" In P. McAllister (ed.), *Reading Bhaṭṭa Jayanta on Buddhist Nominalism*, 217–250.

2018d Kei Kataoka. "Sucaritamiśra on Apoha." *Journal of Indological Studies* 28 & 29 (2016–2017), 25–49.

Also E. Frauwallner. "Beiträge zur Apohalehre II. Dharmottara." *WZKM* 44 (1937). Akamatsu Akihiko. 「Dharmottara の Apoha 論再考」 [Dharmottara's apoha theory reconsidered]. *Indogaku Bukkyōgaku Kenkyū* 33-1 (1984).